Daniel on a Thursday

By Garth Wingfield

(A crowded bar. ABBA's Take a Chance on Me plays in the background (One or both characters may be singing along with the lyrics). Two guys leaning against a wall, facing out, nursing drinks. KEVIN eyes DANIEL for a moment. Then DANIEL, sensing he's being cruised, turns, gives him a once-over.)*

KEVIN: Hey.

DANIEL: *(weakly, not encouraging)* Hey.

KEVIN: *(Extends his hand.)* It's Kevin.

DANIEL: Right ... Kevin ... I don't mean to be rude. I'm sure you're a nice guy and all. It's just, I really don't feel like talking tonight.

KEVIN: Oh. That's fair. *(Beat.)* So that was my one chance with you, and I just blew it, right? Is it my body? Is my body this major turnoff? Or my hair?

DANIEL: Of course not! You're a perfectly nice-looking guy-not my type, as it turns out-but perfectly nice looking . . . Anyway. Good talking with you. *(Beat. They both face out again.)*

KEVIN: So let me get this straight. Even though I don't disgust you outright-and I don't actually disgust you, do I?

DANIEL: You don't disgust me!

KEVIN: Even so, you wouldn't shake my hand.

DANIEL: What are you talking about?

KEVIN: I held out my hand to introduce myself, and you wouldn't take it or tell me your name even. It's a handshake! A HANDSHAKE!

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *My friends tell me all the time how bored they get with dating.*
ACTOR 2: *"It's the same date every time."*
ACTOR 1: *(mimicking) "I just go to the same place, and end up on the same date!"*
ACTOR 2: *"It's like Ground Hog day … same date, different guy!"*
ACTOR 1: *Well, I'm here to tell you that YOU are in charge of your own dating destiny!*
ACTOR 2: *Things just feel so repetitive and dull . . .*
ACTOR 1: *Then do something different. It's time to change things up!*
TOGETHER: *Daniel on a Thursday by Garth Wingfield.*

DANIEL: Oh my God, no-NO! I didn't mean to / insult you, believe me.

KEVIN: *(cracking up)* Daniel! Take it easy, man! It's Kevin . . . Kevin Carpenter. From high school. I'm just screwing with you, buddy.

DANIEL: Kevin Carpenter?

KEVIN: From history class. I saw you just now and said to myself, "Well, if it isn't little Daniel Delmonico from high school in a gay bar. I haven't seen him in years. I know what! I'm gonna go over and mess with his head."

DANIEL: No, that's . . . Wow, you know . . . I've gotta be honest here. I don't remember you at all.

KEVIN: You don't? No, that's cool. It's not like we were ever friends or anything.

DANIEL: We weren't.

KEVIN: Not at all.

DANIEL: *(not sure about this)* Right … But … it's good to finally meet you now. After all these years. *(little smile)* You know, this is actually very cool because … the whole time I was in high school, I was fully convinced I was the only gay person there.

KEVIN: You may well have been. I'm straight. Hundred percent hetero.

DANIEL: But this is a gay bar ….

KEVIN: I know that.

DANIEL: So … what are you doing here?

KEVIN: I don't know, I was walking down the street, , and I saw this place-and hey,

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I enjoy an old *Golden Girls* episode as much as the next guy. Gay people are A-OK by Kevin Carpenter. *(low)* Don't worry, I won't tell the old gang your little secret.

DANIEL: What secret?

KEVIN: That I saw you here.

DANIEL: Actually, that's not a *secret* really ... and ... what old gang?

KEVIN: Your pals from high school. Daniel's old buds.

DANIEL: But I didn't ... back then, I didn't have that many close ... *(suspicious)* Exactly who was in my old gang?

KEVIN: You know. *(reaching)* Like ... Mary ... Bill ...

DANIEL: I didn't know anyone by those names, Kevin. So I'm pretty sure you've got / the wrong guy.

KEVIN: *(cracking up)* GOTCHA! Two for two for the Kevinator! I totally had you going there, didn't I?

DANIEL: So you didn't go to my high school. ...

KEVIN: Negatory. I've never even seen you before tonight. But you were buying it, the whole thing, I could tell. Right up to the Bill and Mary part.

DANIEL: Look! **Kevin**! Why don't you just leave me alone, okay? I said I didn't want to talk to anyone, and I don't know why you 're doing this to me. So just ... let's just say ... good night.

KEVIN: Hey, I hear ya. Nighty night. *(They both stare forward for a moment.)*

DANIEL: *(still out, low)* How did you know my name?

KEVIN: *(Giggles.)* I knew you were gonna say that.

DANIEL: HOW THE HELL DID YOU KNOW MY NAME?!

KEVIN: *(getting angry himself)* Whoa ... easy there, Paco. ***Someone*** left his ATM card at the cash machine next door. With his ***name*** imprinted on it. I called out to you on the street, but you didn't hear me. *That's* why I followed you in here. I couldn't give a flying flapjack about *The Golden Girls*. *(Handing him*

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back his ATM card.) I was being Kevin Good Guy. Got it?

DANIEL: Well ... that was very nice of you. *(Hates to say this.)* Thank you ...

KEVIN: *(still testy)* Damn right about that. *(Then, suddenly bright.)* Say, lemme buy you a [drink]!

DANIEL: No, Kevin, please ... I just want to finish this one and go home.

KEVIN: Oh, come on! What're you drinking? Beck's? I'll bet you always drink Beck's. I bet you've been drinking Beck's for years.

DANIEL: That's ... I have.

KEVIN: Well, prepare to break new ground, my friend, because tonight you are drinking a Breezer. Voila! *(He pulls bottled Breezer from the inside pocket of the jacket he's wearing, twists off the top, and hands it to DANIEL.)*

DANIEL: Okay, you ... so you always bring your own ... ?

KEVIN: *(insulted)* Jeez, ixnay on the udgment-jay. I'll have you know I bought this legit from the bartender before I walked over here. *(Significantly.)* I knew I could convince you to drink it. I walked in here just as you were buying your [Beck]. And I watched as you took the change and filed it away methodically in your wallet, making sure all the bills faced in the same direction, and I said to myself, "That guy-Daniel Delmonico from the ATM machine really needs my help."

DANIEL: I don't always do that / with my money.

KEVIN: He's in a rut, and I'm gonna do my part to pull him out of it. I'm gonna make him switch drinks, if only for a Breezer. It's a baby step, but there you go."

DANIEL: *(a little wounded)* I'm not in a rut.

KEVIN: Please, you're here every Thursday!

DANIEL: *(suspicious)* How do you know that?

KEVIN: *(fast)* Ummmm-I'll bet. I'll bet is all I meant. You just seem like that kind of guy. If it's Thursday night, it's Daniel at this bar. Am I right? And why is that,

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Daniel? Is your life so empty that you feel you have to cling to these meaningless little rituals?

DANIEL: What? No ... *No . . .* this means nothing!

KEVIN: Oh, it means plenty, Daniel. It speaks volumes about you. On the subway platform each morning, where you do stand? Anywhere? Or always in the same exact spot because you know where the train doors will open?

DANIEL: *Look,* just because you bought me a drink doesn't entitle you to grill me like this!

KEVIN: Grill? Who's grilling? I'm merely observing. And asking. Observing and asking. And what's with this ***type*** thing? What's that about?

DANIEL: *(Stops at this.)* What ... type thing?

KEVIN: Apparently, I'm not your **type**. Or so you said.

DANIEL: You're NOT GAY!

KEVIN: That's not the point. What *is* your type? I bet I can guess it. Latin guys.

DANIEL: *(startled)* Why would you guess that?

KEVIN: It's Latin guys, isn't it? Isn't it? I'll bet it is. It's Latin guys. Isn't it?

DANIEL: YES! I'M INTO LATIN GUYS! SO WHAT?!

KEVIN: So what? I'll tell you so what, Daniel Delmonico from the ATM machine. You're losing out on a world of possibilities and, and ***experiences*** that have nothing whatsoever to do with Beck's or Bea Arthur and Betty White. I don't mean to crawl up on a soapbox here but you are severely limiting yourself in many aspects of your personal life.

DANIEL: *(bemused)* Oh, am I? Well, in my own defense, I'd like to point out that I happen to like my life exactly as I've made it. I like knowing what I'm getting.

KEVIN: Loosen up, Dan.

DANIEL: It's **Daniel**, Kev.

KEVIN: Right, fine. Daniel. Let's take what happened with us here tonight-and let's forget about my wife, Viveca, for the moment. And our daughter, Amber, and Helaine, our little finch bird. Let's talk theoretically.

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DANIEL: Theoretically . . .

KEVIN: A guy walks up to you in a bar. Me. This stranger could hold the possibility of, I don't know, one-night that blossoms into a deep friendship involving marathon phone calls and hilarious e-mails! Or. OR! This stranger could be the man you were supposed to spend the rest of your life with. The man you've been waiting to meet ever since you had a crush on your fifth-grade math teacher.

DANIEL: I didn't realize I was gay until high school.

KEVIN: Uh-huh, and so this stranger turns *to* you. Me, I do that. And I say, "Hey," and you say, "Hey," but that's where it ***stops*** in your mind because my name probably isn't Hernando.

DANIEL: Kevin ...

KEVIN: That's no way to wander through the world, my friend. But ... *(Glances at his watch.)* Sheesh, I've gotta get going. It's Amber's birthday today. She turned four. She's gonna get her first Barbie in about half an hour.

DANIEL: Wow, really ... tell her happy birthday for me.

KEVIN: Will do. Hey, you have a good night, Daniel Delmonico. It was cool sharing a drink with you.

DANIEL: Yeah ... Yeah, it was. *(KEVIN starts to go, then stops.)*

KEVIN: May I ask you just one more little question? Now that we've talked, now that you know me a little ... would you give a card-carrying Caucasian guy like me a chance? *(Then.)* You would, wouldn't you? Wouldn't you? You would. Wouldn't you?

DANIEL: *(laughing, frustrated)* CHRIST, YOU DRIVE ME TOTALLY INSANE!! I don't know .... I guess you are sort of charming. In a totally psychotic kind of way. Sure, what the hell. *(Little beat.)*

KEVIN: AND SCORE THREE FOR THE KEVINATOR!!!

DANIEL: No way ... no way ... Hold on, so you're actually ... ?

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KEVIN: Yep, full-on gay. Completely queer. I knew you were coming around! I could tell!

DANIEL: Get away from me, okay? Leave me alone forever, starting right now.

KEVIN: What are you talking about? We have a date to go on, cowboy.

DANIEL: Are you insane? No! No, we do NOT!

KEVIN: After *all that WORK?!* Do you have any idea how DIFFICULT that was, thinking on my feet like that? I totally forgot little Amber's name there for a full thirty seconds. ·

DANIEL: There is no way I am *ever* going on a date with you, Kevin ... if that is your real name.

KEVIN: It's actually Hernando, which is pretty ironic. *(off DANIEL's look.)* THAT WAS A JOKE!!

DANIEL: See, that's why I won't go out with you. *That* is my point exactly.

KEVIN: Oh, come on ...

DANIEL: Come on what? We could get to some restaurant, and you'd tell me that you're really a woman. Or that you're Vietnamese. Or that you're a VIETNAMESE WOMAN! And this whole thing would turn out to be some extended con! You lied to me repeatedly!

KEVIN: I didn't lie-fine, you want to know who I am? *(DANIEL rolls his eyes.)* I'm a guy who's been corning to this bar on Thursdays for months, who noticed you weeks ago and thought you were certifiably cute, only you looked right through me. So when you left your card at the ATM machine, it seemed like I was being given this chance. And ... I just wanted you to *see* me for a few minutes. For one conversation.

DANIEL: AND YOU COULDN'T JUST SAY, "HI, I FOUND YOUR ATM CARD?!"

KEVIN: Sure, but how unoriginal would that have been? And I didn't lie to you, for the record. I *surprised* you. I kept you guessing. And for a while there, near the end, you were pretty intrigued by me, I could tell.

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DANIEL: ... I don't even know what I'm supposed to say to you.

KEVIN: How about we just ... let's just ... *(Turns to him, anew.)* Hey.

DANIEL: *(after a pause)* Hey.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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ABBA's Take a Chance on Me lyrics and music can be found on
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-crgQGdpZR0

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